

Five Ways to Restart a Stalled Lesson

For the moment you can feel the room has gone.

5 moves

INSTRUCTIONAL STRATEGIES

BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

If anyone could get hurt, get another adult.

Restraint and seclusion are not de-escalation tools. Imminent danger only, trained staff only. [NASP 2021]

CHANGE WHAT THEY ARE DOING

1 Stop talking and give them a question.

Thirty seconds in pairs. The point is to break the listening posture, not to gather answers.

SAY

Turn to the person next to you. Thirty seconds. Go.

2 Move the room.

Standing, regrouping or shifting seats resets attention faster than asking for it.

CHANGE WHAT YOU ARE DOING

3 Drop your volume instead of raising it.

A quieter voice makes the room work to hear you, where a louder one competes.

Works better in smaller rooms.

4 Name what you are seeing, without blame.

Describing the room accurately is usually enough to change it.

SAY

I have lost about half of you. That is on the task, not on you.

5 Cut the lesson short and say why.

Ending early with a reason costs less than fifteen minutes nobody absorbs.

What is deliberately not here

Any technique for you to walk the student through. That is treatment, and it is not your job here.

Sources: NCTSN Child Trauma Toolkit for Educators pp.4-6; NASP 2021.